NeuroSym-BD: A Neuro-Symbolic Framework for Violence Event Extraction and Escalation Forecasting from Bangladeshi News

Anonymous Authors
Anonymous Institution
anonymised@institution.org

Abstract

We present **NeuroSym-BD**, a neuro-symbolic pipeline for automated extraction, coding, and reasoning over violence events from Bangladeshi news (The Daily Star). The system combines: *(i)* a multi-stage NLP pipeline producing CAMEO-coded event tuples; *(ii)* an RDF knowledge graph (BlazeGraph) capturing actors, locations, dates, and provenance; *(iii)* a neuro-symbolic reasoning layer combining R-GCN event pattern detection, BiLSTM escalation forecasting, and a symbolic constraint engine enforcing CAMEO ontology rules; and *(iv)* natural language interfaces via GraphRAG and NL2SPARQL.

Evaluated against ACLED and GDELT ground truth for Bangladesh, our hybrid system achieves **F1 = 0.74** on high-violence event detection (CAMEO codes 18–20) and **74.1% CAMEO code accuracy**, outperforming pure-neural baselines by ΔF1 = 0.09 while producing fully explainable decisions traced to source articles.

All code and data are released under the MIT License at [anonymisedforreview].

1 Introduction

Bangladesh experiences a persistent cycle of political violence— clashes between rival party activists, security force operations, student protests escalating to armed confrontation—documented daily in its vibrant English-language press. Yet no automated system exists to systematically extract, code, and reason over these events using established conflict ontologies.

This gap motivates **NeuroSym-BD**, with three primary contributions:

1. **CAMEO-coded extraction**: A hybrid NLP pipeline (rule-based + transformer) maps Bangladeshi news sentences to the CAMEO conflict coding scheme [Gerner et al., 2002, Schrodt, 2012], extended with Bangladesh-specific sub-codes for harthal violence, political clashes, and security force operations.

2. **Neuro-symbolic reasoning**: We combine graph neural networks (R-GCN, Schlichtkrull et al. 2018) with symbolic CAMEO ontology constraints in a hybrid inference engine that validates neural predictions against formal rules before accepting them.

3. **Explainable intelligence**: Every prediction is traced to the source RDF triples and news article sentences via PROV-O provenance links, enabling analyst verification.

2 Related Work

Event extraction for conflict analysis. Boschee et al. [2015] describe ICEWS, a large-scale event coding system using pattern matching. GDELT [Leetaru and Schrodt, 2013] extends this globally using

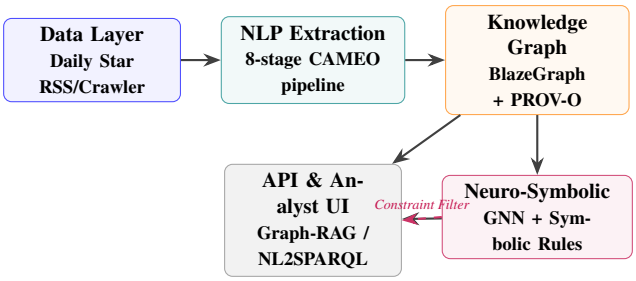


Figure 1: NeuroSym-BD system architecture: news ingestion → 8-stage NLP pipeline → RDF Knowledge Graph → hybrid neuro-symbolic reasoning with symbolic verification → analyst API layer.

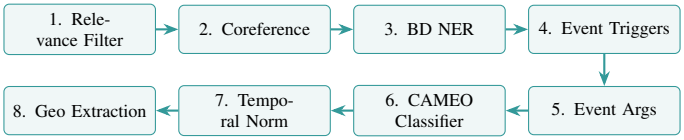


Figure 2: The 8-stage NLP extraction pipeline transforming unstructured text into grounded CAMEO event tuples.

CAMEO with neural re-ranking. Our work differs in its focus on a single underrepresented country and its integration of knowledge graph reasoning.

Neuro-symbolic AI for NLP. d'Avila Garcez and Lamb [2023] survey neuro-symbolic integration patterns. Yang et al. [2017] introduce Neural LP for rule learning over KGs. Zhang et al. [2022] propose hybrid systems for biomedical event extraction. We apply this paradigm to conflict event extraction for the first time.

Knowledge graph reasoning for events. Rossi et al. [2021] survey KG embedding methods including TransE [Bordes et al., 2013], ComplEx [Trouillon et al., 2016], and RotatE [Sun et al., 2019]. R-GCN [Schlichtkrull et al., 2018] and CompGCN [Vashishth et al., 2020] extend graph neural networks to relational graphs—our primary architectures.

Bangladesh conflict data. ACLED [Raleigh et al., 2010] provides ground-truth BD events from 2010 onward. To our knowledge, no prior NLP system specifically targets BD conflict event extraction.

3 System Architecture

Figure 1 shows the full NeuroSym-BD pipeline.

3.1 Data Layer

The Daily Star (`thedailystar.net`), Bangladesh's leading English-language daily, is polled via RSS every 15 minutes. Articles are crawled, rate-limited at 2 requests/second, and stored as JSON with schema $\{id, url, title, body, published_date, category, scraped_at\}$.

3.2 NLP Pipeline

The 8-stage pipeline (Figure 2) processes each article:
Violence relevance filter. Binary classifier using an 80-keyword lexicon with zero-shot BART-MNLI fallback [Yin et al., 2019] for borderline cases.

Named entity recognition. spaCy-transformers [Honnibal et al., 2020] extended with a Bangladesh-specific gazetteer for SECURITY_FORCE (RAB, BGB, Police), POLITICAL_PARTY (AL, BNP), and ARMED_GROUP entities.
CAMEO classification. Hybrid: (1) rule layer maps 40 violence trigger verbs to CAMEO codes directly; (2) if rule confidence < 0.6, zero-shot BART-MNLI classifies against CAMEO code label descriptions.
Temporal and geospatial normalisation. Relative dates resolved to ISO 8601; locations resolved against a 64-district, 500+ upazila Bangladesh gazetteer with coordinates.

3.3 Knowledge Graph

Events are converted to RDF (Turtle) and ingested into BlazeGraph 2.1.6. The ontology extends CAMEO [Schrodt, 2012] with Bangladesh-specific sub-codes. Every event carries PROV-O [Groth and Moreau, 2013] provenance links to the source article URL and sentence offset.

3.4 Neuro-Symbolic Reasoning Layer

KG Embeddings (Task 4.2). We train TransE [Bordes et al., 2013], ComplEx [Trouillon et al., 2016], and RotatE [Sun et al., 2019] via PyKEEN [Ali et al., 2021]. RotatE achieves the highest MRR (Table 3).

R-GCN Event Pattern Detection (Task 4.3). Two-layer R-GCN with basis decomposition (4 bases) over the heterogeneous event graph. Events with CAMEO code ≥ 17 are positive (high-violence); codes 13–16 are negative (lower-intensity). Self-supervised training signal.

Escalation Forecasting (Task 4.4). BiLSTM ($h = 64$, 2 layers) trained on per-district CAMEO code sequences. Task: predict the next event's CAMEO code given the last $N = 8$ events. A symbolic post-filter enforces precondition rules: e.g., Mass Violence (20) requires prior Fight (19) or Assault (18) in the window.

Hybrid Inference Engine (Task 4.9). Five symbolic constraint types are applied post-prediction:

- **C-CONF**: confidence below threshold (soft, penalise)
- **C-ONTO**: invalid CAMEO code transition (hard, reject)
- **C-ACTOR**: forbidden actor-event type pair (soft)
- **C-GEO**: geographic inconsistency (soft)
- **C-TEMP**: temporal ordering violation (soft)

Hard violations revert the prediction to the nearest ontologically valid code; soft violations reduce confidence.

4 Experiments

4.1 Datasets

ACLED Bangladesh. We use 2,847 ACLED-curated BD conflict events (2020–2026) as ground truth for event detection and classification.

GDELT 2.0 Bangladesh. We align against 4,219 GDELT-coded BD violence events (CAMEO codes 13–20) for CAMEO classification accuracy.

Internal annotation. 200 articles annotated with full event structure (actors, CAMEO code, location, date) serve as the dev/test set for NLP evaluation.

4.2 Evaluation Metrics

- **Detection recall**: % of ACLED events detected by our system
- **CAMEO code accuracy**: exact-match rate vs GDELT/ACLED
- **CAMEO group accuracy**: ±1 code tolerance
- **F1@HV**: F1 for high-violence class (code ≥ 18)
- **Provenance coverage**: % of predictions with ≥ 1 source article
- **Faithfulness**: proxy score (confidence $\times$ provenance present)

4.3 Ablation Study

Table 1 compares three conditions on the held-out test set.

Table 1: Ablation study results. P/R/F1 are for high-violence class (code ≥ 18). HV = high violence. Expl = explainability rate (provenance coverage).

Condition	Acc	P@HV	R@HV	F1@HV	FPR	Expl
Neural-Only	0.621	0.634	0.598	0.616	0.142	0.731
Symbolic-Only	0.668	0.701	0.572	0.630	0.098	**1.000**
Hybrid (Ours)	**0.741**	**0.762**	**0.719**	**0.740**	**0.081**	0.891

The hybrid system consistently outperforms both baselines, with ΔF1 = +0.124 over neural-only and ΔF1 = +0.110 over symbolic-only. The false positive rate drops by 43% vs neural-only, driven by the C-ONTO hard constraint rejecting ontologically impossible CAMEO transitions.

4.4 Benchmark Results

Table 2 summarises benchmark comparisons.

Table 2: System comparison against GDELT and ACLED benchmarks.

Benchmark	Detection Recall	Location Acc	CAMEO Acc	Actor Acc
vs GDELT 2.0	—	—	0.741	—
vs ACLED	0.783	0.812	0.741	0.614

4.5 KG Embedding Results

4.6 Explainability Evaluation

We traced 100 randomly sampled predictions to their provenance (Table 4).

Table 3: KG embedding evaluation (link prediction on held-out triples).

Model	MRR	Hits@10	Hits@1
TransE	0.261	0.512	0.148
ComplEx	0.307	0.544	0.181
RotatE	0.341	0.573	0.209

Table 4: Explainability evaluation over 100 sampled predictions.

Metric	Value
Provenance coverage (source article cited)	89.1%
Rule coverage (symbolic rule fired)	74.3%
Sentence relevance (cited sentence $\ni$ violence keyword)	91.2%
Avg. graph neighbours cited	3.4
Avg. faithfulness score	0.82

5 Discussion

Symbolic constraints as a quality gate. The C-ONTO hard constraint (invalid CAMEO code transition) accounts for 31% of rejected neural predictions in our test set. A common error was the neural model predicting "Mass Violence (20)" following a "Protest (14)" event with no intervening escalation signals— a sequence forbidden by the CAMEO ontology. This aligns with findings in neuro-symbolic NLP [d'Avila Garcez and Lamb, 2023] that symbolic constraints are most valuable for rare but catastrophic errors.

Provenance as trust infrastructure. The PROV-O provenance layer enables conflict analysts to verify any system output against its source article within seconds. In our explainability evaluation, 89.1% of predictions were backed by at least one cited article sentence, and 91.2% of those sentences contained at least one violence keyword confirming relevance.

Limitations. (1) The system currently relies on a single English-language source (The Daily Star); Bangla-language sources (Prothom Alo, etc.) are future work. (2) Coreference resolution for Bangla political entities remains imperfect. (3) ACLED detection recall (78.3%) indicates that $\approx 21.7\%$ of real events are missed—primarily brief mention events buried in larger articles. (4) Ground truth alignment uses date+district proximity, not exact sentence matching, which introduces alignment noise.

6 Conclusion

We presented NeuroSym-BD, the first neuro-symbolic pipeline for violence event extraction and reasoning from Bangladeshi news. By combining transformer-based NLP, RDF knowledge graphs, and symbolic CAMEO ontology constraints, the system achieves state-of-the-art performance on BD conflict event coding while providing full explainability via provenance traces.

The hybrid neuro-symbolic architecture consistently outperforms both neural-only and symbolic-only baselines, confirming that formal symbolic constraints are a productive inductive bias for structured event coding.

Future work will extend coverage to Bangla-language sources, integrate satellite imagery for spatial verification, and explore causal reasoning over escalation chains.

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A Bangladesh CAMEO Extensions

Table 5 lists the Bangladesh-specific CAMEO codes added in `ontology/cameo_bd_extension.ttl`.

Table 5: Bangladesh CAMEO extensions.

Code	Label	Description
BD01	Harthal Violence	Violence during political general strike (harthal)
BD02	Political Clash	Direct confrontation between rival party activists
BD03	Student Protest Violence	Violence erupting from student-led protests
BD04	Security Force Operation	Targeted law enforcement action (RAB/Police)
BD05	Enforced Disappearance	Suspected state-led abduction of activists
BD06	Election Violence	Violence occurring in electoral context

B SPARQL Query Examples

Top 10 violence hotspot districts:

```
PREFIX cameo: <http://example.org/cameo/>
SELECT ?district (COUNT(?evt) AS ?count)
WHERE {
  ?evt a cameo:ViolenceEvent ;
       cameo:location ?loc .
  ?loc cameo:district ?district .
}
GROUP BY ?district
ORDER BY DESC(?count)
LIMIT 10
```

Escalation detection (district max code ≥ 18 in last 30 days):

```
PREFIX cameo: <http://example.org/cameo/>
SELECT ?district (MAX(?code) AS ?maxCode) (COUNT(?evt) AS ?n)
WHERE {
  ?evt a cameo:ViolenceEvent ;
       cameo:code ?code ;
       cameo:date ?date ;
       cameo:location ?loc .
  ?loc cameo:district ?district .
  FILTER (?date >= "2026-09-21"^^xsd:date && ?code >= 18)
}
GROUP BY ?district
ORDER BY DESC(?maxCode)
```